Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, Section 107) which allows use for commentary, criticism, news reporting, research, teaching or scholarship without requiring permission from the rights holder.

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (315) 859-4071.

Phil Mead

Phil Mead is a proud member of Hamilton College's class of 1959. Always a music fan, he has recently retired from a successful career in the field of medicine and now devotes even more time to his trombone. Phil speaks fondly of his Hamilton music experience and his current involvement with the Alumni All-Stars.

Phil was interviewed in Clinton, New York on June 1, 2006 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming at Hamilton College today for the Jazz Archive. And I'm very pleased to have another Hamilton alum, Phil Mead, class of '59, here today. Welcome.

PM: It's good to be here. Thanks for having me.

MR: Thank you. You mentioned that this is one of your favorite rooms, we're in the browsing room.

PM: I spent many, many very happy hours, and I hope I learned something. I did all my reading in this room and it never was terribly popular. I don't know why. So I could always get a seat and I would bring my *David Copperfield* or whatever had been assigned and sit here and read and I always have very warm memories. It's great to be here.

MR: That's great. And of course you lived on this side of campus because that was the side.

PM: That's the only side there was, that's right.

MR: You are the second Hamilton alum I've interviewed, the other one was Milt Fillius who was class of '44. But I asked him and I'm going to ask you, I've always been impressed by the loyalty of a significant number of Hamilton alums. And is there a reason for that in your mind?

PM: Well I surely agree with you, it's remarkable. It was true in my case, I still have very close friendships with many of my classmates and yet both my sons went here, one class of '88 and one class of '90 and they have exactly the same friendships. And indeed those friends are now friends of my wife and I. We often on New Year's Eve will get a call from a Lieutenant JG in Tokyo who is stationed there and is just calling us up to wish us a Happy New Year. And it's a remarkable thing. And I don't know if it's the smallness of the school — I've always thought the isolation might have had something to do with it. Certainly when I was there, and I'm not sure it's a great deal different, your friends were the people that you went to college with because there wasn't much else around. And so whatever it is it's been great through my lifetime and it's great to see it happen to my sons.

MR: Right. You didn't have to go down the hill for too much, or maybe there wasn't too much to go for.

PM: Down the hill for our haircuts, and that was about it.

MR: Yeah. Do you remember what your tuition was?

PM: I believe it cost about two thousand dollars to go to Hamilton when I started in 1955. And I was just chatting with my wife on the way over here today — the reason I think that's about right is I pretty much was able to pay my way through Hamilton and I used to make — I had a six hundred dollar state scholarship, those were New York State's scholarship, and I used to make about six hundred dollars playing with the Catatonic Five, which was a pretty good pay in those days, and a long summer job. I could usually eke out fifty dollars a week so that was another six hundred dollars. So I think my dad had to come up with a couple hundred and I got my Hamilton education. So it's different today.

MR: Yeah. Very different. But at the time, can I guess that you didn't feel like you were getting a tremendous bargain? I mean you were working for it and it wasn't for free.

PM: Certainly it had been my goal to go to college and to go on to medical school and so this was just in the plan and because of the scholarship and the band and the summer jobs it all worked out and so you just sort of — that was the plan and you hewed to it and it worked out and you were glad it went as planned.

MR: Yeah. Well when you were here was there an active music department?

PM: Very much so. John Baldwin had come I think a few years before and of course was starting his reign as just an outstanding choir director, a technically just stupendous organist. I don't know if you ever were fortunate to hear John play the organ but he really was a wonderful musician. And so there was that, and then there was the jazz which I'm sure we'll get into. And then Berrian Shute was the old professor of music and used to have us down to his home and we'd listen on the old scratchy 78 records in the evening, we'd listen to opera. It was a different era but it was very intimate and for music that's the best.

MR: Do you think there's a difference now with — music is so available in huge quantities to younger people through iPods and internet and the whole thing, where during your era and my era it was not so getable all the time. Do you think it makes a difference?

PM: Well I'm not sure. That's an interesting hypothesis. Something that I've noticed through the years is when I was growing up playing a musical instrument was kind of a big deal and many people did that. And of course it was the era of a town bands and all of that. I notice today in Vermont that's very true. There are lots and lots of young musicians, middle school kids, who really are great players and who take great pride in their playing. Interestingly when my boys were at that stage, and so that was more in the seventies, sports seemed to be more important. And so I don't know if that's a biased thing I'm

seeing where I live or if there's something to that. But I would say that I don't think there's a big difference between today and the old days. I think there are a lot of really good musicians around and I think ultimately live music is what's exciting and what makes it work. So I'm looking for a resurgence if you will, when all these young cats get out of school and get to play, and maybe we'll see more of that. But I certainly agree with you. It seemed like in the seventies and eighties it was more we listened to music rather than played it. It would be fun to get back to the playing it.

MR: Right. Well my daughter actually did a little research for me and she came up with some of the top ten hits of around the mid-fifties. And they have such songs as "Oh My Papa" by Eddie Fisher and "Don't Let the Stars Get in Your Eyes," Perry Como, "That's Amore," Dean Martin. And then even into the rock & roll era with Bill Haley and the Comets. Now nowhere on this list are any Dixieland hits. So tell me why you came to Hamilton and were able to find people like yourself who were still into that music.

PM: Well let me go back a little bit —

MR: Yeah, please.

PM: — in my history. My dad, who actually was a great runner, qualified for the 1928 Olympics, went to Wesleyan, but loved music. And was a pretty decent soprano saxophone player. You can relate to that, had a nice Buescher soprano saxophone which he played at Wesleyan. He graduated in 1928. But then he became a self-taught jazz piano player and was actually a very good piano player. And my earliest remembrances are dad, when he'd come home from work at night, he would play the piano. And he would play all the great old tunes. "Jada" and "Curse of an Aching Heart" and on and on, all the great old Dixie tunes. And as a child I just grew up with that. And I used to hum those tunes just because I heard them all the time. We then moved to — we moved around a lot. My dad worked for the telephone company in Upstate New York and was moved every few years. We then moved to Syracuse and when I was about ten they gave free music lessons at Edward Smith Junior High School in Syracuse. And I wanted to take trombone lessons. But you had to furnish your own instrument and we were careful with our money as Depression Era families were, and so he said, "Well you can take my saxophone." So I learned to play the saxophone and actually became pretty good at it. So then he got me a tenor sax. And by then we had moved to Schenectady. And they have some good musicians in Schenectady including a band, Donny James and his Orchestra. High school kids, very good. This was around 1948 to 50. I was around ten or twelve. And of course those were the great swing bands, Glen Gray and all of that, and they had all those charts. And so the tenor player in this dance band was a catcher and he couldn't play in the summer so I got recruited even though I was only twelve. And I could read like crazy. I couldn't solo very well but I could read like crazy. So I was sitting up there

in this sax section just, just loving it. And so then I got a clarinet because you know you have to double, and so I thought of myself as a clarinetist and saxophone player. My dad at this point began having jam sessions in our house and we'd invite people over. And my high school music teacher, a guy named Chief McNally, who was a trombonist, had been brought up and his parents were Salvation Army folks. And you're not supposed to leave the Army. You're supposed to stay in the Salvation Army if you're a child. But he was so good he went on the road with some big bands, played with Red Nichols and then got in the Navy and came home, fell in love with one of his childhood sweethearts who was also a Salvation Army child and she convinced him — she couldn't convince him to go back into the Salvation Army but she did convince him to come off the road and to be a music teacher. So he was my teacher. This is a long story.

MR: It was a bit of a compromise on his part but a good one.

PM: A good one. Although he didn't last that long in high school music. In any event, so that's about the time that I decided I wanted to go to Hamilton College. And I heard — great they had a Dixieland band. And I'd been listening. I was kind of brought up as a swing player but I'd been listening to Dixieland and my dad would occasionally take me down to New York to Eddie Condon's. He was a great Condon fan and I became a great Condon fan. So I heard they had a Dixieland band at Hamilton and the leader was a guy named Emerson Brown. So I called Em up and told him who I was and I said, "Do you have a spot for a clarinetist?" He said, "No, because I'm the clarinetist and I'm the leader," he said, "but we need a trombone player." And I said, "I think I've got one for you." So I went over to Chief McNally and he sold me his trombone, which was a great trombone, a 1932 Martin Committee model.

MR: You're still playing it.

PM: Well I have it but I don't play it, it's a little pea-shooter, but just a wonderful horn, I love it dearly. And he sold me that and I came to Hamilton not knowing how to play the trombone but knowing a lot about Dixieland music and basically that was how I got started.

MR: That's a great story, and you had great motivation to learn the music because you had, hopefully, a spot to go for it.

PM: So that all sort of fell together. And I can remember that first night I was at Hamilton I heard somebody over at what we used to call Silliman Hall playing the piano, and it was Derry Hall.

MR: Derry?

PM: Derry Hall. And Derry went to Hamilton and actually played with some of the jazz bands there and actually was a guy who played piano for us at Carnegie Hall with the Catatonic Five. But I took my horn over there and he was very nice to me. He'd just graduated that

year or a year before, and we played a little bit and then I met Emerson and the Catatonic Five came together and that's how it all happened.

MR: Now what's the history — do you know about the history of the name the Catatonic Five?

PM: I really don't. And I bet you Donny Andre can tell you about that. And Dick Sherman will give you the history of jazz up to that point. But this was fall of '55. And the band that came together was Em Brown, who was a senior, he was the clarinetist and the leader, Donny Andre was a sophomore and the banjo player and became the manager of the band and really did a yeoman job getting the gigs and doing all the hard work of running a band, and myself, a brand new trombonist just trying to learn how to play the trombone. We were the three Hamilton guys. And then Johnny Johnson — two guys from Colgate — Johnny Johnson who was a technically brilliant pianist from Colgate and went on to be a high school music teacher and Peter Ill who was a trumpet player from Colgate. And I don't know what happened to Peter after he graduated. And then we always had remarkable drummers. And the two guys who played the most for us were Ronnie Zito — Ronnie was a young kid, probably 16, 15 from Utica, and he played with us a lot. He loved to go on these gigs, he loved my jokes, he just had the best time, and he was just a powerful drummer. He had the greatest time in the world. And he was supposed to go to Europe with us but his mother wouldn't let him go. But Ronnie of course went on to become a famous drummer and made some great sides with Woody Herman, some of the I think some of his classics — "Opus de Funk," the old Horace Silver tune with Ronnie Zito on drums. Just an unbelievable, powerful, big drummer.

MR: And from a very musical family too, with Tori who went on with Tony Bennett and all that.

PM: So then the other guy who mostly played with us was Jimmy Wormworth, and he's sort of the guy who I think of as our drummer because Jimmy and I became very close friends. But Jimmy was my age so he was 18 starting out and he was a bop drummer. Ronnie was always a big band drummer. I mean he could play anything but he was a big band, swing band drummer. But Jimmy was a bop drummer, a wonderful drummer. And he and I became very close friends and stay in touch to this day. And he of course was the drummer for Lambert, Hendricks and Ross, played with almost everybody in the fifties and sixties and just had a remarkable career and is still playing now with Charles Davis and still, I heard him a couple of years ago when they came up to Vermont and he hadn't lost a beat. He's wonderful. So those were two. And then occasionally when the two of them couldn't make it there was a guy whose nickname was Grogan and I'm trying to come back with his name, but he was a marvelous drummer. So we had these just killer drummers. And I think they really kicked the band along. And I think everybody in the

band was a pretty good musician but the drummers were certainly spectacular. I don't think there was any other college band then or now that had this kind of talent just week in and week out just kicking you along. And so I think that had a lot to do with the excitement at the beginning and of course once we got playing then it just all kind of came together.

MR: So were you playing the same kind of repertoire that the Alumni All-Stars play now?

PM: I think we were a little more New York-Chicago based. I'm never happy with the labels very much.

MR: Yes it's hard to label things.

PM: But I mean the real, as you can imagine, with Jimmy Wormworth on drums it was basically a bop drummer, we were a four beat Dixieland band, which is sort of interesting because we didn't have a bass most of the time, we had a banjo. So it was kind of a unique mix to have the standard front line of trumpet, clarinet and trombone, but then sort of this mixed up rhythm section of a bop drummer, a really sort of classical or outstanding cocktail pianist piano player and a banjo player. But it worked fine. But I think we played much more — I can't say swinging because I think the All-Stars swing now. But it was much more four beat and it was much more like Condon's stuff. We were influenced very much in the fifties by what was going on in New York. Central Plaza, Nick's, Condon's.

MR: So the group didn't really think of itself as playing — I'm not sure how to put this — but old music.

PM: That's right. This was our music. You put it perfectly. This was our music. This was what was happening. I mean in those days New York City was the center of the world. I mean there was no other city that came close to it. And the jazz music was at New York City, was at Nick's, the Central Plaza, and it was this kind of Dixieland. And of course all the great guys were playing then and we thought of that as, we did not think we were playing our father's music.

MR: Okay.

PM: But it was sort of interesting because we were and that was sort of one of the neat parts of it that we were playing this old stuff. I mean a tune like "Curse of an Aching Heart" is an old, old, old tune and yet you can make it swing like crazy and we did.

MR: That's really interesting. And I'm trying to picture — you played for frats, frat parties.

PM: Mostly fraternity parties. The places we played most, we played at all Cornell house parties. And that was sort of interesting too because in those days at Hamilton we had Saturday classes and you really weren't supposed to cut classes, particularly if you were pre-med you really had a tough schedule. So a typical house party weekend at Cornell would be like this. I'd finish up my lab at maybe four o'clock on Friday afternoon, we'd

load up, Em had a Studebaker. The doors didn't close very well so we always referred to them as Fallopian doors, and I became an obstetrician, and those were the Fallopian doors. And we'd load the car up and so we'd get down to Cornell about six o'clock and get set up at one of the fraternity houses and you know, get playing along about eight, and quit about midnight. Then those of us who had Saturday classes, and the seniors often didn't but you know I was a freshman or sophomore. So I would borrow Em's car at twelve o'clock, get in the car and drive back to Hamilton, I'd go to classes, and then get done at noon, grab a little lunch, get back in the car, drive back down, get down there at two, we usually played at a picnic in the afternoon, then we played in the fraternity house at night. We never had any hotel rooms or anything. We'd sleep on floors or on couches or occasionally you'd find a dorm room that was open that had a bunk you could climb into, and scrounge food where you could. And then there was always a milk punch party in the morning at one of the fraternities at Cornell. We always played that gig. And then get in the car and come back here. And at seven o'clock you had compulsory chapel and then you were back in the lab for the week. That was a typical weekend.

MR: Let me rewind just a bit. What's a milk punch party?

PM: Oh milk punch was a concoction of milk and ice cream and liquor, and all mixed up. Sort of like if you took half of a vanilla milkshake and put an equal amount of booze in it and those were very popular in those days, Sunday morning milk punch parties.

MR: Sort of the hair-of-the-dog type things.

PM: Very much. Very much.

MR: That's a great description of your weekend. How much money would you have netted for that kind of work?

PM: Usually for each of those gigs you'd get about twelve dollars so as you could see I mean you might, I mean those were big weekends. Most times you'd just go out there'd be a Saturday night row. But you know you could make fifty, sixty dollars. And every once in a while there'd be a very wealthy alum there who loved Dixieland that would come up and give everybody in the band a twenty dollar bill.

MR: That's a big event, isn't it. That's great.

PM: But just to finish up one thing, so we didn't think of ourselves in the Catatonic Five as playing traditional jazz. And we frankly didn't listen to a lot of traditional jazz. I mean we were much more listening to the stuff that was going on in New York, so Turk Murphy and Kid Ory and stuff like that, not that we didn't like it we just didn't deal with that very much.

MR: Right. I think it's how musicians usually learn music is they grab what's happening at the time and then if they get interested to go backwards they will. Like gee where did this come from, who do you suppose these people listened to.

PM: That's exactly what's happened to me. I mean now at the age of 69 I'm actually going back and listening to Kid Ory and George Brunies and some of these people and it's remarkable stuff.

MR: And the people you played for, did you ever have some of the frat fellas like, "Play some rock & roll?"

PM: Not in those days. They loved the stuff. And that's I think the sad part of the world for me today is that the audience is going away. It was so much fun. I mean you'd go in and you'd have just throngs of people. You know on a nice spring evening you'd wind up on some terrace you know and half the Cornell football team would carry the grand piano out on the terrace and it would be a nice night and there'd be all sorts of people. They loved the music and it was so much fun. But that's what the music was. Rock & roll really hadn't — we were just a little before that, really Elvis got going while we were — really after we were out of college.

MR: Okay. Yeah because that was a sort of a — I don't know if I would call it a down time for pop music but there wasn't anything really strong for a number of years there so I think your timing was pretty good for that.

PM: Some people who are historians and know about this stuff really think that Elvis was a watershed. And some very fine musicians believe that, you know, he wasn't just a kind of a great pop guy, I mean he really made a huge difference in how we all thought about and listened to music. Leonard Bernstein said that.

MR: I've had a number of musicians say that. Yeah, that that was a big transition from swing to straight-eighth notes is how some of the musicians would characterize it. That's terrific. And your parents thought this was a pretty good way for you to make a buck?

PM: They not only, of course my dad loved music so much that he was happiest when he was either playing or listening. I mean this guy played until he was 97 and he just finally just ran out of steam. In fact the last time I played with my dad we were playing and I was thinking you know, this guy on piano, his time is rock solid and his harmonies were just delicious and then all of a sudden I'd think wait a minute, that's my dad, he's 97. But he was 95 then I shouldn't exaggerate. He was 95. But every once in a while we'd be playing a gig and you'd look out and there were mother and dad, they had their drink in their hand and they were right there cheering the band on and they would drive up to these things just to listen. And people were always very nice to them, they'd always get them drinks and they had a good time.

MR: That's a great feeling. I had a similar circumstance when I was actually in my rock & roll days, my parents would come out and support the band even though it probably wasn't their cup of tea.

PM: In fact there's a funny story about that that sort of goes along with the other stuff we were talking about, that as I said we always had these spectacular drummers except one night all three of them couldn't make it. We had a gig at Hobart. And so they suggested this other high school kid. So I mean we were so spoiled by Ronny Zito and Jimmy Wormworth and Grogan that we were just wow, this guy's probably just as good. Well we got out there and he was just dreadful, he was awful. And I felt badly for him because he was a young child and he just was out of his element. But the band just sounded awful. So as it turned out my folks had driven all the way from Albany to Geneva New York, which is a pretty good hike, to hear the band. They walked up and down listening for the band and when they heard this they said, "That can't be the Catatonic Five because they always have good drummers. So they went home which was just as good because we didn't play well that night.

MR: I'll be darned, they never even found you, they just said no that wasn't us.

PM: They said that wasn't us if they have a drummer like that.

MR: I'm going to ask you about something you said, you said, "We didn't play or listen to much traditional jazz." So what is traditional jazz for you?

PM: Well again as I said, I have trouble putting labels on things. Some of the real West Coast Turk Murphy kind of stuff, I guess I never particularly enjoyed that. And I've never had much opportunity to play it so maybe if I did I would. But as I say I'm getting more and more blurred as I begin to go back now. Now probably at the moment my two favorite trombonists, after for years being kind of fan of bop trombonists, I mean J.J. Johnson and Jimmy Cleveland were my heroes, and still are, and yet as I listen to Teagarden, I think he's head and shoulders above anybody, he's just playing stuff — and now Dick Sherman has got me listening to George Brunies and as I listen to him I think wow. And technically these guys are excellent. This idea that the old musicians weren't great technicians is crazy. George Brunies is every bit the technician that any of the great bop players are. The most I listen I think good people playing almost anything are fun to listen to.

MR: Was the band an entity at Hamilton as well? It sounds like you went off campus to play a lot of your gigs.

PM: Yes. Good question, and I think in two ways. Number one, Hamilton was very small then, you know six, seven hundred students. Very isolated. The interstate had just opened, I mean so things were very much clustered around here. So everybody knew what was going on. And if we all got snowed in here we'd have a jam session. There were some other musicians here. There was a guy named George Rudder who had a piano player who is actually a very good piano player who plays out in the midwest. He had a band called the Oriskany Rhythm Kings and Em always thought it was much better

than the Catatonic Five. But anyway, so we'd get together and play. We'd play for house parties here obviously. Occasionally they'd hire us as a jam session here and so everybody knew the band and it was kind of a — music in those days, live music, was a focal point of parties. I mean you'd get a band and then you'd have a party, which was sort of neat. And so you needed to have the band to have the party. So in that sense we really were a part of the college. The other thing I think was that we were one of the top Dixieland bands in the collegiate circuit in those years. There were other very good bands — Tigertown Five was at Princeton was probably the most famous, Spring Street Stompers was a great band from Williams. They had a wonderful trombonist although I was never sure he was a matriculated student.

MR: Oh. He was a ringer.

PM: The High Street Five from Wesleyan. There are a handful of them but the Catatonic Five was highly rated. The fact that we played at Carnegie Hall in '56, and toured Europe that same year, so I thought it actually reflected very favorably on the college. Here's this little tiny college that's got the best Dixieland — one of the best Dixieland bands in the country, and was getting a lot of press. And I think we were proud of that and frankly, I'm not sure Sandy McEwen was very proud, you know Sandy who didn't allow no jazz on Sunday—

MR: Oh you can't just gloss over that you have to tell me about that.

PM: Well I'll let Dick Sherman tell you about that, that's his story. But the president was a Presbyterian minister and he wasn't much of a jazz fan. But I think most people thought it was great. I mean gee, here's a big placard, there's a midnight jam session at Carnegie Hall on November 24 and it's Hamilton College. And who announced this but Jack Crystal, Billy Crystal's dad. And so I think it was good for the college and I think people recognized that.

MR: And how did that gig come about?

PM: Donny Andre will have to tell you that. Don was just great about getting these various gigs for us including the one to Europe which was wonderful.

MR: Did you play on a boat?

PM: The only job we had was going over then coming back on the Holland America lines. These were little ships. They'd been on the Indonesian line and they put them in this summer service for the students. These were small ships. We left on June 23, 1956, my 19th birthday that's why I remember the date, on this little ship, and played ten days over. These were small, slow ships, just students. And you can imagine, it was a ten day house party and we'd play it over, and then we came back the first week in September on the Ziter cruise which was another Holland America line ship. Now two key things happened in the summer of '56, you will remember one of them probably. Three days after we left

Clifford Brown was killed. He died on June 26, 1956 on the Pennsylvania Turnpike. Clifford was always my favorite musician, just technique, soul, whatever, just unbelievable. And we learned that on the ship. That was sad. The other thing that happened that summer was the Andrea Doria was sunk. And that's fifty years ago exactly, 1956. And most people went back and forth to Europe on ships. Plane travel was very tough then. You really had to go up to Gander, Newfoundland and then over to Greenland and then over to Shannon. So people went by ship. But when a ship went down, holy mackerel, there were a whole bunch of people who didn't have any way to get back from Europe to the United States because the ships were full, so they kind of squeezed some extra people in on our trip back in September because of that. We had a Texas oil millionaire on the ship with all these college kids, and he loved to play poker, and so the band would play and he would play poker with all of the students on the ship and he lost, in those days, some incredible amount of money, I don't know, twenty thousand dollars, which to him wasn't nothing, but a lot of kids got their tuition paid. And when he got off the ship he said "great music, it's the best trip I ever had, the most fun I ever had."

MR: I wanted to go back to Hamilton for a moment. A lot of colleges these days have big problems with alcohol on campus. What was it like during your years here?

PM: I think we had big problems. I think that's one thing, I'm sure it hasn't gotten better but I'm not sure it's gotten worse. I think there's always been a tremendous amount of drinking on college campuses. Certainly where I live the University of Vermont this is a problem and I think it's a problem everyplace.

MR: Okay. So it wasn't so much connected to the drinking age per se, which is higher now, but did it change the issue?

PM: I don't think so. That's not a very scientific answer but I don't think so. I think we had a lot of drinking in those days.

MR: Tell me a little bit about playing with Emerson and what was he like back then?

PM: Emerson I always thought was an excellent leader. He was a very dogmatic guy — a my way or the highway kind of guy — very much in control, which I think is good in a leader. Certainly as a young guy who'd never done this kind of stuff before it was very helpful to be told what to do and how to do it and all of that. Emerson was also very nice to me. He helped me with some of my studies and I always — when you're sort of new and unknown and somebody helps you get over the rough spots you always remember those people. Emerson could be a very difficult person to work with. He was not always the friendliest person and he could be downright mean at times. And yet because he had helped me out so much as a freshman I always thought of that and then you know, sometimes when he was a jerk — he really isn't, he's a good guy, he's just doing that. So

I thought he was a great leader and I think a lot of the success of the band was due to his musical leadership, to Donny's wonderful ability to do all the behind the scenes stuff, and to these just killer drummers who just drove us at these tempos that would just knock your socks off. So I think those three things had a lot to do with it.

MR: You must have progressed pretty quickly as a trombone player I guess, in keeping up with that company.

PM: Well you know there weren't a lot of recordings made. We actually have a recording from Carnegie Hall but other than that there isn't much. I wished I did because it would be fun. I've asked, since I've retired in the last three years, I've actually taken up the trombone after playing it for fifty years and I actually study with a guy at the University of Vermont, Peter Bouchard, who is a classical trombonist, and I've certainly learned a great deal about playing the trombone and I think I'm a much better trombonist now. But you know, you've sure got good chops when you're 18 and you sure don't when you're 69 so I don't know. I've had some discussions with some trumpet players about this. And some people feel that hearing my dad play, you know, a couple hours a day every day of my life probably until I went to college, probably was the best thing that could have happened to me. And so with our own grandchildren we always have jazz on the — have a CD going. And you know what they like — and we have a pretty wide collection — and you know what they like the most?

MR: What is it?

PM: Ellington.

MR: No kidding.

PM: Which is fascinating. Because I listen to a lot of hard bop, I listen to a lot of Dixieland, a lot of swing, a lot of thirties and forties stuff now and I'm even getting back into New Orleans stuff. There's all that stuff on, and I love the big band, you know, Woody Herman and Stan Kenton. But they actually like Ellington, which I think is good.

MR: And you still play LPs?

PM: Oh no.

MR: You're all CDs.

PM: All CDs.

MR: You're a CD guy now.

PM: All CDs.

MR: The All-Stars nowadays, you guys get together once a year, or maybe, is there other times that you're able to get together?

PM: Well we had been getting together in the spring down in Washington because the trumpet player and the banjo player of course are down there and we have a son who lives in Washington so we like to go down there, and everybody likes to go to Washington. So

we had been getting together in the spring and in fact last year we got together and practiced and then actually had a gig, had a couple of gigs. But this year we didn't have any gigs so it's getting harder to travel so this will be a one-timer. Having said that I think everybody in the band is playing a lot now so we're not playing with these players but we're playing with other bands so that makes it, so it comes together pretty quick.

MR: So nobody shows up here and like plays a note and then goes oh, gee, my chops are like —

PM: No not at all. No everybody's playing a lot.

MR: That's good. When you improvise on a particular song, are there things that are going through your head as far as note choices relating to chords or is it more of a hearing —

PM: It's almost exclusively hearing because I'm not trained in chords. And actually the guy I'm studying trombone with now, who is a fine classical, he's tried to teach me the chord thing and I can't do it. And it's because it's so much easier to do it the other way and I guess at age 69 it doesn't make a whole lot of sense to learn a hard way to do something.

MR: That you're already doing.

PM: But the thing that I do notice about my improvising is that as I am now playing a lot more you begin to, there are just certain licks that you put into your brain that come out and that didn't happen before, and I sort of agree with the people that say, I still think that's improvising. Because you play it a little differently every time.

MR: Oh certainly.

PM: And if you listen to Teagarden, I mean if you listen to his breaks on "Royal Garden Blues," you know half of the time they're the same ones. But why not? They're spectacular.

MR: Yeah. That's style.

PM: He plays them a little differently and it's not like a symphonic trombonist who would play this measure and it would sound exactly the same every time. No. So I do notice that change now, which is I think good, not bad.

MR: Well don't let your teacher spoil you by making you do something that seems unnatural. You know some of the greatest players, Zoot Sims and those fellas, are not as it's called schooled in that, but the ears are all-important.

PM: You've got to listen all the time. When young players ask me, "What should I do," just listen to good people all the time, and it doesn't particularly matter. I even listen to some symphonic stuff. But just listen to good music all the time. And it's certainly easy advice to follow.

MR: Well you sound like as a young man you had a career goal in mind and you achieved that and you had a long career in the medical field.

PM: Yes. And medicine is obviously demanding. I was the Department Chair of OB-GYN at the University of Vermont so that was demanding and so I really kind of fit in music very much around the edges. And unfortunately when I'd come up here to play at reunions it was very much, like you say, I'd play a couple of tunes and I'd say, "Man my chops are dying." But people put up with me, which was good of them. But when I got ready to retire I had always hoped that I could get quite serious about the music and so that's when I started the music lessons and I actually play in church brass groups and concert bands, and just Vermont bands in the park for the summer. It just helped my reading and just as a chance to play and hear other musicians, and that's been fun, so I've been able to be very serious about it for the last three years.

MR: Did Hamilton have a concert series while you were here that brought jazz musicians to campus?

PM: Yes they did. And that was interesting. We had more bop musicians than Dixieland players at that time. In fact probably the best concert I ever heard was J.J. Johnson, Tommy Flanagan, Tootie Heath, who was about 15 years old, and the cornet player was Nat Adderley.

MR: Oh my.

PM: And I remember it was over in Commons, what we call Commons, and they got up on the stage and J.J. said, "My schedule's been messed up and I can only play for an hour, I'm going to play for an hour straight." And it was one of the best hours of jazz I ever heard, because that was a great supporting cast. And then he had found a whole bunch of old guys — and I should know their names but I don't — who came up with him and he said, "They're going to do the second half of the concert." Well these were guys who didn't get to play a lot I guess. They were wonderful musicians, and of course they had the best time. So that thing went on for about four hours and that was a great afternoon.

MR: I'll bet. And I love Nat Adderley.

PM: Yeah. And he was, I mean these guys were very young. This would have been the spring of '58. And it was just the height of that season. I can't remember who the bass player was on that job but you know Tommy Flanagan was —

MR: What's the connection between the Catatonic Five and the Fallacious Five? Was that a little bit before?

PM: That was before. And I think Emerson and Donny perhaps were the — that was, you know Paul Parker was here when I was a student. He was a professor but he played some but not a great deal. But that was a little before. And you stand on the shoulders of giants. That's what got it all started. And then we just came at the right time.

MR: Isn't it interesting, at least I feel in those times, when you're 18 and someone's 21 back in those times, and they have more experience, they just seem so much older and wiser and everything. Then you get older and three years is almost nothing.

PM: It's a lifetime, and particularly you're coming from high school to college, and then an upper classman, wow.

MR: Well we have a lot in common, we have the music, we have children who went to Hamilton and I'm really pleased to have been able to gather your thoughts about this whole thing. Is there anything that you'd like to add to what we've talked about?

PM: No, I think we've covered it. It was a remarkable time in my life. I think back to those days with just the greatest happiness. And I'm loving playing with the Alumni All-Stars now, so music is just a happy thread and I just hope I can keep playing 'till I'm 95 like my dad did.

MR: Oh that's a great thought. And as a sort of outside observer but someone who's had the pleasure of sitting in a few times I can say that in the last number of years I've noticed a real jump in the band's, the whole sound you're putting out. It's been great to hear.

PM: Well come and hear us tonight — tomorrow night.

MR: I will. All right. Well thanks for your time. It's been a real pleasure.

PM: Thank you sir.